

Complimentary video

We have included an exclusive video on the Digit DVD this month to give you a feel of the ebook readers we have tested



eBook test

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Leaf Touch Mega

This ebook reader from Leaf is a rather large one and weighs a massive 510 grams. Although we could give you a discourse on holding a device that weighs half a kilo to unwind and read, we'd leave that for later. It also has a capacitive touch screen, but that didn't impress us either. On the good part, it reads almost all the formats you can think of and has a 9-inch screen that lets you read magazines and newspapers at ease. But it wears you out rather quickly and you'll soon want to keep the device aside and roll your wrists a bit for relief.

For most part, it makes sense to opt for this device for commercial use rather than personal use. It makes a better enterprise tool instead of a personal reading companion that we'd rather prefer. Add to that its price tag of nearly ₹26,000 and you'd be better off with a touch-capable swivel netbook or a tablet. And yes, it does have an email client that you could configure your mailbox to, but considering the lag and the effort it takes to type on the QWERTY keyboard, it seems unlikely you would ever use this for email. The Mega Touch highlights the mail box on its home page, but not the browser. When we initially explored the Mega, we thought it didn't have a browser. That, we believe needs to improve – its UI.

It has a pair of speakers built into it, but they don't reproduce sound as effectively as we desired. The Mega has optional 3G. In fact it had a SIM card slot, but unlike Amazon's offering of free global coverage, you'd have to shell out massively to stay covered at all times. We're Indians – every rupee counts.

Amazon Kindle

Despite being 0.5-mm slimmer than the Infibeam Pi, it has managed to accommodate a 3.5-mm audio jack instead of the lousy 3-mm jack we mentioned in the Pi. Although there are limitations in the number of formats supported by Amazon, these limitations are compensated by the sheer volume of books Amazon has to

offer on the Kindle store.

If popular opinion counts, you can be sure of strangers walking up to you and enquiring about the device you're using. Many around you find the resemblance to paper unbelievably real to be a display. When we passed the Kindle around our office, there was the typical excitement of having made a discovery.

In addition to the brilliance in design, the Kindle also supports social networking. You can highlight a portion of the text you are reading in your vast collection, and share

it as your status on Twitter or Facebook, complete with a short URL – for free! In addition, the inbuilt browser is effective and free global 3G really helps. Whether you're at home, in office or travelling, the least you get is free email!

Another feature in the Kindle is text-to-speech. Your Kindle can read the book to you, and sounds much better than the Microsoft's text-to-speech tool. You can alternate between a male and female



Amazon Kindle: Companion

voice. In addition, the Kindle has some hidden features, including a game of Gomoku and Minesweeper. Also, it lets you take screenshots of the page you are reading, and has a scientific calculator. To know more about hidden features in the Kindle, go to bit.ly/dhV1oJ.

On the down side, the Kindle doesn't read DOC files, so you would have to convert files to either of the ebook formats and

transfer them manually. Instead, Amazon converts your document and delivers it to you instantly for a "tiny" fee of 15 cents per MB. If you are considering buying an ebook reader, the Kindle definitely ranks high. Of all the ebook readers we looked at, the Kindle and Leaf Touch Pro were the only ones to distinguish between 16 shades of gray.

For one, the level of white on the screen is far more important than the levels of grey – it's text we're talking here – a darker shade of gray instead of black doesn't really matter. What's more noticeable is the underlying white, anything that best mimics paper will capture your attention. 



Mega Touch: Heavyweight

WHICH EBOOK READER IS RIGHT FOR YOU?

QUICK RESPONSE

If you need a quick system that responds fast, then the Kindle is your safe bet. The next option in that order would be the Leaf Touch Pro and Mega, followed by Infibeam Pi and Leaf Touch.

WEIGHT

If unwinding is why you need an ebook reader then you would definitely consider weight, because heavy devices tend to strain your wrists. This time, the Infibeam Pi literally outweighs the rest significantly. It's the lightest of all. Followed closely by the Leaf Touch and Amazon Kindle.

FILE FORMATS

If file formats are critical to you, then the Leaf Touch Mega is the one you should be looking at. It supports nearly all formats you could think of. In fact, it supports more formats than the Kindle.

EASY DOWNLOADS

Nothing beats the fact that you can use the Kindle 3G anywhere in the world to access the Kindle store – click download and start reading a minute later!

OUR VERDICT...

Our test results rate Amazon's Kindle as the Best Performer. For its price and also considering its rich feature set, we recommend it as the Best Buy. The only sub-₹10,000 ebook reader, the Infibeam Pi, is our Editor's Pick. We look forward to testing many more ebook readers, and also expect to see many more Indian players jump on to the E-Ink bandwagon, so keep your eyes peeled for those as well.